Button jaws

Button jaws or Cole jaws are an easy and convenient way of holding the rim of a finished bowl to remove the foot or holding method. They comprise eight dovetailed rubber buttons that can be moved to different positions of the jaws to accommodate different sizes of bowl. To demonstrate the button jaws I've turned up a small bowl measuring 180 x 75mm out of Indian Laurel (*Terminalia alata*). I've left a sacrificial foot on the bowl measuring 65mm diameter x 4mm deep which now needs to be taken off. Here's how to do it...

1 Set up the button jaws in the chuck ready to accept the bowl – with the jaws already set to the correct position. To make the job of opening and closing the jaws in the chuck easier I recommend a long chuck key as this will stop the key and chuck fouling each other

2 The bowl is now attached to the button jaws and ready for the foot to be turned off

3 Turning the foot off with a 6mm bowl gouge, be careful to keep the bevel rubbing which will help prevent the gouge from catching

4 After sanding and polishing I've left a small radiused foot on the bowl to finish the piece off

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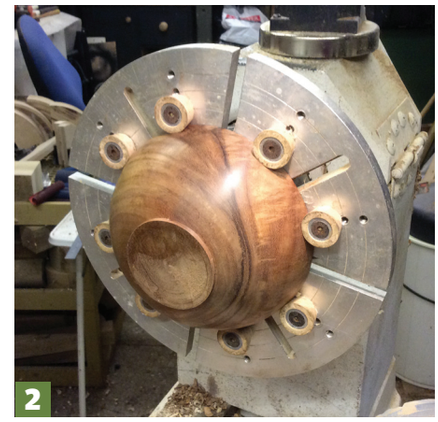
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Woodplate jaws

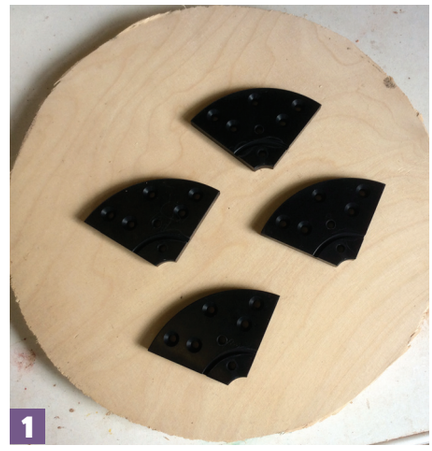
Woodplate jaws work in a similar way to button jaws, but require some work before they can be used. They can be made to a size and shape to suit your project and have a much greater surface contact area than Button jaws. This is by far my favourite jaw for reversing bowls. The best material for your jaws would be a good-quality plywood, I use birch (*Betula pendula*) ply as I find this has no voids unlike some cheaper alternatives. Most of my wood jaws comprise two layers of 25mm plywood enabling me to create lots of hold points. Here's how to do it...

1 Take your good-quality plywood and a set of plate jaws. I'm making a set of 360mm jaws and have already cut the plywood to a circle

2 Divide the disc into quadrants. First, mark the centre and draw a straight line through it. Using this line and a square, draw another line 90º to this one dividing the disc into four

3 After marking the disc into quadrants, cut through the line. For this I'm using a bandsaw

4 Now that we have four pieces we need to number the jaws in the order they were cut. These numbers will then be matched up with the numbers on both the plate jaws and accessory mounting jaws in order to keep everything running concentrically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